

BOOK REVIEW

Avery Cardinal Dulles. (2005). *A History of Apologetics* (2nd ed.). San Francisco: Ignatius Press. 417 pages. \$18.95 paper. ISBN 0898709334.

Textbooks that survey the scope and history of argumentation routinely ignore the rich, Christian apologetic tradition. In doing so they not only render an injustice to that tradition, but they also deprive scholars and students of the opportunity to learn about apologetic uses of, and contributions to, argumentation practice and theory. Ignoring this impressive body of work is comparable to excluding the writings of Augustine from a history of rhetoric or those of Aquinas from a survey of Western logic.

The study of Christian apologetics is not merely of historical interest, however, nor is it the exclusive concern of theological specialists. Indeed, in recent years there has been renewed interest in its study and practice. This interest is not surprising, given the growing number of Christian adherents here and abroad, rising interest in religion in general, and the increased influence of Christianity and other religions within the public sphere during the past decade. Prompting—and prompted by—these trends, an abundance of apologetic literature is being produced today, which draws from and contributes to a tradition of religious argumentation that dates back two millennia to the very origins of Christianity. Anyone interested in understanding the role religious argument has played, and continues to play, in advancing, defending, and shaping the Christian faith should be thankful that renowned Jesuit scholar Avery Cardinal Dulles has published a revised version of his much admired historical survey of Christian apologetics. This timely release is part of Ignatius Press' Modern Apologetics Library.

Cardinal Dulles is the son of former U.S. Secretary of State, John Foster Dulles. A convert to Catholicism, he entered the Society of Jesus (Jesuits) in 1946. A decade later he was ordained a priest. In a long and productive career as a scholar he has published 22 books and over 700 articles. On February 21, 2001, Pope John Paul II elevated him to the rank of cardinal, though Dulles was not then a bishop as is typically the custom. Instead, the pope promoted him in recognition of his work as a theologian. He is the first American to be honored in this way, reflecting the respect his scholarship commands. Currently, the cardinal is the Laurence J. McGinley Professor of Religion and Society at Fordham University.

Charting the history of Christian apologetics from its ancient origins to its recent resurgence is an ambitious task. Cardinal Dulles renders the undertaking manageable by narrowly defining the scope of his project, focusing upon Christian apologetics aimed at addressing non-Christians. This criterion excludes from consideration the work of controversialists, apologists who argue that one sect (e.g., Southern Baptist or Evangelical Lutheran) is a truer and more authentic expression of Christianity than other sects. It also excludes those apologists who specialize in defending particular partisan doctrines, such as the virginity of Mary or *sola scriptura*. It excludes as well Christian polemicists who attack the faith traditions of others rather than defending and promoting their own. While the simplicity of this definitional plan is conceptually appealing, in practice it proved difficult for Cardinal Dulles to adhere to it, as various apologetic and polemic purposes often inform the same work.

Cardinal Dulles organizes his survey of Christian apologetics chronologically, rather than thematically. He does more, however, than merely chart the historical development of Christian apologetics from its origins in first century Palestine to our own time. He also examines how shifting cultural, political, religious, scientific, and social contexts shaped the development of that tradition; identifies major apologetic approaches and themes; and describes the different types of argument used to defend and promote the Christian Faith. As one would expect from a sweeping survey of this type, Cardinal Dulles devotes most of his attention to historically significant apologists from each era, while other less prominent apologists are merely mentioned in passing or ignored altogether. It is obvious at times that he is far more interested in, and comfortable with, Catholic apologists than those belonging to other Christian sects, though he does attempt to do justice to such prominent Protestants as William Paley, C. S. Lewis, and Karl Barth.

In the first chapter, Cardinal Dulles points out passages in the Gospels, the Acts of the Apostles, the Pauline epistles and other New Testament books which, he argues, serve an apologetic purpose. These passages constitute the earliest extant uses of apologetic argument in the Christian tradition, and in some cases represent the preservation of apologetic discourse embedded within an oral tradition that predates the writing of the Christian scriptures. Chapter Two provides a deservedly prolonged discussion of the apologists of the Patristic Era (from about 100 CE to 800 CE). During the early part of this period, the cardinal notes, Christian apologetics served two primary purposes: to render Christians safe from martyrdom by arguing that they and their faith posed no threat to Roman rule; and, to frame Christianity as a legitimate, and for some apologists *the* legitimate, inheritor of the

Mosaic and prophetic traditions of the Jewish people. These apologetic foci clearly reflect the exigent circumstances—and associated concerns—of the fledgling faith, and they profoundly influenced the nature and shape of apologetic arguments. Cardinal Dulles notes that apologists who worked during the latter part of the Patristic Era turned toward classical Greco-Roman philosophy—most especially the neo-Platonism of Plotinus and his student Porphyry—for ammunition in arguing the case for Christianity. In part, their willingness to take this turn reflects the improved circumstances in which Christians found themselves after Constantine legalized Christianity with his Edict of Milan (313 CE). Since those Christians inhabiting the Roman Empire were no longer threatened with martyrdom, it was not necessary to defend their faith against the charge that it posed a political threat to Rome. This safety allowed Christian apologists the luxury of defending the tenets of their faith instead of defending themselves. The quantity and quality of the work done under these newly favorable circumstances contributed to their growing confidence in engaging with pagan philosophers on their own terms. In addition, the use of philosophical concepts and terms immeasurably enriched the then nascent Christian theology in ways that continue to influence today.

Chapter Three is devoted to the Middle Ages, an important period in the development of Christian apologetics, during which such theological giants as Abelard and Thomas Aquinas built upon and extended the work of previous apologists while also making creative use of newly recovered Aristotelian texts and drawing upon and responding to the work of their Islamic and Jewish contemporaries. Chapter Four describes the history of apologetics from the Reformation through the Enlightenment. The Reformation prompted an explosion of controversialist apologetic literature as Catholics and Protestant scholars argued with one another. Unfortunately, given the way Cardinal Dulles defined the limits of his historical survey, scant attention is paid to this period's sectarian disputes. As a result, such important Reformers as John Calvin and Martin Luther are given short shrift, as are Robert Bellarmine and other major figures of the Catholic Counter-Reformation. More attention is given to apologetic responses to the Enlightenment. During this time, troubling scientific discoveries seemed to challenge revealed truths. This challenge required new approaches to apologetics, such as William Paley's famous argument from design, an argument which plays an important role in today's hotly contested Evolution/Intelligent Design debate. During this same time, Christian apologists were also confronted with the need to address the religious indifferentism of an increasingly secular Western culture, which held "that no religion is demonstrable and that all are of equal value" (p. 156). The legacy of this religious relativism still exercises a strong social influence.

For this reason, addressing secular relativism has in been a major theme of the homilies, lectures, and writings of Pope Benedict XVI, both prior to and during his papacy. (Interestingly, it should be noted, the current pope is conspicuously absent from Cardinal Dulles's discussion of contemporary apologists. This is indeed a strange omission, given the influence of Benedict's prolific output during the past few decades, and the fact that several pages are devoted to the work of his immediate predecessor, John Paul II.)

Chapter Five offers an overview of the nineteenth century, a period which Cardinal Dulles argues "is unquestionably one of the most fruitful in the entire history of Christian apologetics" (p. 267). This century produced such influential apologists as the German hermeneutic pioneer Friedrich Schleiermacher and John Henry Newman, a Catholic convert whom the cardinal calls one of the greatest apologists of all time. The last two chapters, Six and Seven, are devoted to apologetics produced during the twentieth century. As described by Cardinal Dulles, "From the point of view of apologetic productivity, the first half of the twentieth century registered both progress and decline" (p. 323). Theologians of that period were less inclined to engage in apologetic argumentation than their predecessors from the previous century. Some, like Karl Barth and Rudolph Bultmann, went so far as to warn "against apologetics on the ground that [in its use of rational argumentation] it neglected the quality of faith as a grace" (p. 323). Given such disinclination and outright antipathy, it is not surprising that some of the period's best and most innovative apologetic argumentation was not produced by trained theologians, but rather by literary apologists such as C. S. Lewis and G. K. Chesterton. Two apologetic trends dominate Cardinal Dulles' discussion of the second half of the twentieth century: the irenic Catholic apologetic inspired by the Second Vatican Council's call to engage in respectful dialogue with other faith traditions, and the rather unexpected emergence of a robust and rigorous Evangelical Protestant apologetic. In dealing with this time period, he seems most at home describing and assessing the work of his Catholic contemporaries, such as Hans Urs von Balthasar, Hans Küng, and Karl Rahner, which is understandable given the context in which the cardinal has carried out his life's work.

Over time, as Cardinal Dulles is careful to point out, the concerns addressed by Christian apologists changed as their circumstances and their intended audiences changed. As already noted, the earliest apologists were eager to legitimize Christianity and render the faith and its adherents safe. Later apologists responded to challenges posed by Islamic, Jewish, and other religiously-based critiques of the Christian faith; scientific findings and theories—such as Copernicus' heliocentric

solar system and Darwin's theory of evolution through natural selection—seemingly at odds with biblical accounts of the universe and creation; the intellectual doubts of agnostics and atheists; the religious indifference of rational secularism; and the findings of cultural, historical, linguistic and textual criticism that call into question literal and traditional interpretations of the Bible. In responding to these and other challenges, Christian apologists have argued that their faith is unique and true, has historical veracity, is a prophetic fulfillment, is logically necessary, is culturally and morally superior to other faiths and the absence of faith, and is compatible with and complementary to science, etc. In making these arguments, they have employed a variety of methods, including arguments based on prophecy, from signs, and from human experience; aesthetic and teleological arguments; evidential and cumulative case methods; presuppositional apologetics; and cosmological and ontological arguments that respond to, draw from, and extend classical arguments proffered by such pre-Christian philosophers as Plato and Aristotle. Since Cardinal Dulles' purpose in this work is to provide an historical overview of the Christian apologetic tradition, he does not go into much technical detail in his treatment of these and other methods of apologetic argument. Those wanting such detail will need to look elsewhere.

Regardless of the concerns addressed or kind of arguments offered, most apologists operate out of an argumentative framework informed by one of two radically different apologetic approaches: fideism or rationalism. As described by Cardinal Dulles, fideists like Blaise Pascal and Søren Kierkegaard begin with the tenets of the Christian faith and use reasoned arguments to make sense of what they believe for the benefit of themselves and others. This approach to apologetics is in keeping with Anselm's classic definition of theological inquiry as "Faith seeking understanding." In contrast, rationalists such as seventeenth century Spanish Jesuit Miguel de Elizalde claim "that the truth of Christianity can be rigorously demonstrated from the rational evidences [obtained] prior to the gift of faith" (p. 156). These rationally obtained evidences provide purportedly neutral grounds that make possible apologetic dialogue with those who belong to a different faith or no faith at all. Critiques of these two approaches call into question the entire apologetic project. Indeed, though some of the finest minds in the Christian tradition have devoted themselves to making apologetic arguments, Cardinal Dulles acknowledges that there are those who question whether apologetics has any role to play in fostering Christian faith. This doubt is expressed in his discussion of the twentieth century Swiss theologian Hans Urs von Balthasar, whose view the cardinal sums up thus: "apologetics proves either too much or too little. Either it persuades people to believe on the basis of certainty, which is

not Christian faith, or it asks them to believe on the basis of mere probability, which makes faith irrational” (p. 337). However, as Cardinal Dulles states in his concluding remarks, “As long as people ask questions and pose challenges to one another, believers will be called upon to give a reason for the faith that is in them” (p. 367). He cautions, though, that while apologetics can show why the Christian faith is reasonable, “arguments can never prove the truth of Christianity beyond all possibility of doubt” (p. 367).

Of course, we cannot expect a one-volume survey to provide an in-depth and comprehensive treatment of an intellectual tradition that spans two millennia and those cultures and that portion of the world inhabited by Christians. Indeed, no student of apologetics, argumentation, or religious history will be completely satisfied with Cardinal Dulles’ decisions regarding which apologists, approaches, and themes to include and which to exclude. These decisions often betray his cultural and religious biases and interests. There are, as a result, some glaring omissions. For example, discussion of the Eastern Orthodox apologetic tradition is abandoned by the time the cardinal leaves the early Middle Ages. Moreover, except for his justifiably extensive treatment of the North African apologists of the Patristic Era most of Cardinal Dulles’ history focuses upon European Catholic and Protestant apologists, with only an occasional and brief nod to those from North and South America. There is regrettably no treatment of contemporary apologetics in Asia and sub-Saharan Africa, the two regions where Christianity is currently gaining its largest number of converts, and where contemporary Christian engagement with Islam is most frequent—and most contentious. Still, Cardinal Dulles’ *A History of Apologetics* is well worth reading by anyone interested in learning more about the history and practice of religious argumentation. While flawed in some respects, the book is the best survey of apologetic literature currently available.

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